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*Supporting narrated video (NV) demonstrations, high-speed video (HSV) clips, technical proofs (TP), and all past articles are available online at **drdavepoolinfo.com**. Reference numbers used in the articles help you locate the resources on the website.*

In online video (**NV L.46**), I discuss and demonstrate the commonly accepted "bar rules" used in casual, non-league, non-tournament 8-ball play. The differences from the WPA "official rules of pool" are pointed out, examples of common bar rule variations are covered, and many types of shots that are considered “dirty pool” in bar play are demonstrated. I’ll summarize the important points and some interesting examples from the video below.

There is no official rule set for **8-ball “bar rules,”** but here are the generally-accepted main differences from the “official rules” of pool:

1. If you pocket one or more balls on the break, the group with the largest number of balls down becomes your group. In other words, it is “**Take What You Make**.” If an equal number of group balls is pocketed, the table remains open.

2. If the **8-ball is pocketed on the break**, you win; unless you also scratch or jump the cue ball (CB) off the table, in which case you lose.

3. **Every detail must be called** on every non-straight-in shot. That applies to combos, kisses, caroms, rail-first hits, kicks, and banks. If you don’t call the details of a shot, you lose your turn and the CB remains where it is.

4. If you scratch or if the CB leaves the table on any shot (including the break), the opponent gets **ball in hand in the “kitchen”** behind the head string. And the CB must be shot out of the kitchen before contacting a ball or cushion. If the only object ball (OB) is in the kitchen, you need to kick at it. As shown in **Image 1**, you can also use a massé shot, assuming the CB first leaves the “kitchen” before hitting a cushion or ball, in this case hitting the bottom cushion outside the kitchen before rebound back to pocket the 1. See the video for a demonstration of the shot.

**Image 1 Massé shot out of the “kitchen”**

5. If you don’t hit one of your balls first, you lose your turn and the **opponent shoots from where the CB lies**.

6. Others **fouls** under “official rules” are **not called** or penalized. They include not driving a ball to a cushion after ball contact, a double hit, a push shot, a scoop jump, and an intentional miscue.

7. The **8-ball cannot be used in a combination** or with a kiss shot. For example, in **Image 2** shooting stripes, you are not allowed to hit the 11 into the 8 to pocket the 13.

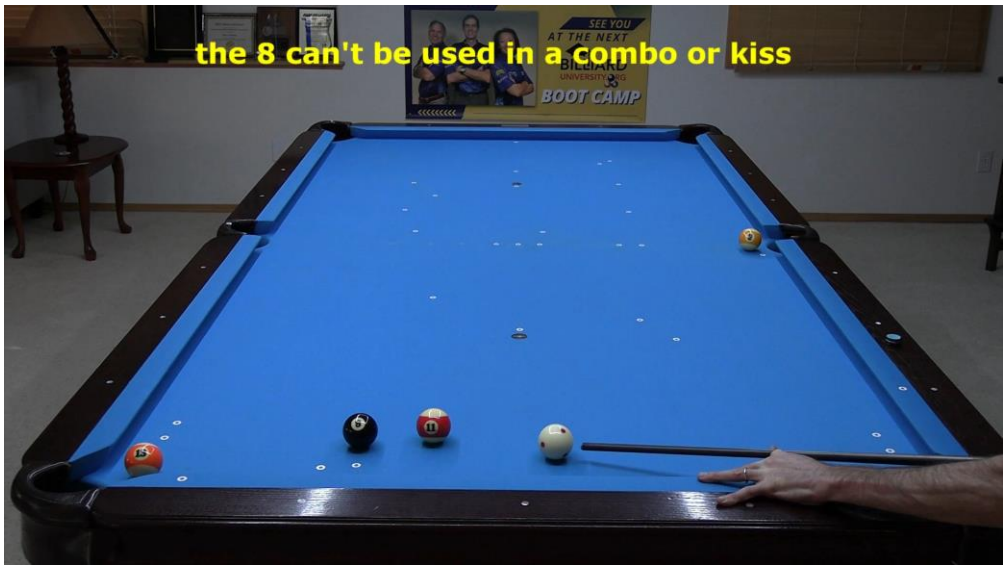


**Image 2 The 8 cannot be used with a combo or kiss shot**

8. When **shooting the 8, a scratch results in loss of game**, regardless of whether you pocket the 8 or not. The same applies to jumping the CB off the table.

9. Defensive play **safeties are considered "dirty pool."** They should not be played unless they are the result of an honest effort to pocket a ball or breakout something when no shot is available. For example, in Image 3, I am making an "honest effort" to pocket the 9 in the left side pocket with a combo two-rail bank, so the two-way "safety" is okay.

**Image 3 "Dirty" two-way disguised safety**

The complete list of **"**bar rule**"** differences (and more detail) can be found on the **bar rules** resource page at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***.

One problem with "bar rules" is there are what seems to be endless variations in the rules depending on where you play and who you play; and sometimes the rules change even during a game, usually to the benefit of your unscrupulous opponent. Below are some common **"bar rules" variations**. In some bars:

1. **No jump or massé shots** are allowed since they can damage the cloth if not executed with proper technique and equipment.
2. The **table is open after the break**, regardless of what is pocketed or not.
3. **Scoop jump shots** are allowed.
4. The balls are **racked with the outside balls alternating**, possibly resulting in balls from one group (solids or stripes) on all 3 corners, creating a big advantage to pocket one or more balls of that group.
5. "In the kitchen" means the **front of the CB must be behind the head string**, in which case the entire CB must pass the head string before contacting a ball or cushion.
6. The **8-ball can be used** in a combination or kiss shot.
7. **Opponent balls cannot be used** in a combo or kiss shot.
8. **Fouls are called**, resulting in loss of turn. They include double hits, pushes, and scoops.
9. **Safety play** is not considered "dirty pool."
10. **Incidental cushion contact** on the way to the pocket needs to be called. And sometimes this applies even with a kick shot or a hit on a pocket hanger.
11. Pocketed **balls spot** when you scratch, unless playing on a coin-operated "bar box."

Again, bar rules can vary a lot depending on who you talk to. Ask a general rule, always ask first (ideally, before playing) to find out what is allowed or what isn't. Better yet, try to convince people to instead play under the "official rules of pool" so there is no question about what is allowed, and since the official rules are well documented and clear and do not penalize smart play.

Under typical "bar rules" there is the potential to play shots that are considered "**dirty pool**." Even though these shots are not officially illegal under "bar rules," they should be avoided to reduce the chances for arguments and potential bodily harm. Below are some examples that are demonstrated in the video. It is dirty pool to:

1. **Dink the CB** with no attempt to pocket a ball, leaving your opponent tough.
2. **Purposely miss an easy shot** to get a break-out and leave your opponent bad. **Image 4** shows an example where I can purposely miss the straight 11 in the bottom-left corner to be able to break out the 9-13 cluster and leave my opponent bad with no look at the difficult 8 up table. You can try to "sell" the miss, but a knowledgeable opponent might be wise to this.

**Image 4 "Dirty" breakout shot**

3. **Scratch on purpose** to achieve some desirable outcome. For example, in **Image 5**, I can call the 9 in the bottom-right corner but hit it into 11 on purpose to break out the 11-13 cluster while purposely scratching in the bottom-left corner. This would force my opponent to shoot from the kitchen at the difficult 1. Although, if you can "sell" this "missed shot" to your opponent, he might not feel slighted, needing to kick at his only ball. Although, as I demonstrate in the video, my "opponent" (me wearing another hat) can totally miss the 1 during an attempted kick and leave me tough on the remaining stripes. Maybe my "opponent" is smarter at "bar rules" than I think!

**Image 5 "Dirty" purposeful scratch**

4. **Hit an opponent ball first to cause trouble**. The video demonstrates an example where my "opponent" shows his smarts by pocketing my only remaining ball to leave me with only a bank on the 8. I reply with another "dirty pool shot", calling the bank, but hitting it too easy "by mistake,"

attempting to hide the CB behind the 8. Unfortunately, I left my opponent a look at his last ball. If you are going to play dirty pool, you should at least be effective. Although, with lots of dirty play like this, somebody is likely to get a thumb broke or a punch in the face.

5. **Play an intentional foul** like a scoop jump, an intentional miscue herd shot, an intentional double-hit "follow shot," a push shot, or an intentional hit on the last opponent ball. Good game-situation examples of all of these are demonstrated in the video.

6. Obviously send the lone 8 to a bad spot without **making an honest attempt to pocket the ball**.

7. **Move a problem ball with your hand or the cue during a shot**. The video shows an example of using this ploy to break out a nearby cluster "by accident."

8. **Intentionally hit an OB with the cue tip** to pocket an impossible shot. I show an example in the video where I exaggerate a follow through on a shot to pocket a called ball that is impossible to make with a legal shot. Fortunately for my opponent, I also pocketed the 8 by accident to lose the game. I deserve that for trying to play dirty pool. Sometimes the Pool Gods are watching and penalize dirty play.

Again, if you don't want to get a thumb broke, it is probably best not to attempt these types of shots under "bar rules," unless you are playing somebody who tries them on you first. Then, go for it … unless the other guy is bigger, stronger, and meaner.

I hope you enjoyed my overview of "bar rules" and "dirty pool" shots. Be sure to check out online video **NV L.46** so you can see game-situation examples of everything. And if you want more information, check out the **rules resource page** at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***, where I document and demonstrate the WPA "official rules of pool," list all league rule differences, and summarize "bar rules" in much more detail.

Stay clean, and good luck with your game,
Dr. Dave

normal video

**NV L.46** – BAR RULES and DIRTY POOL – Why Official Rules are Important

PS:

- I know other authors and I tend to use lots of terminology, and I know not all readers are totally familiar with these terms. If you ever come across a word or phrase you do not fully understand, please refer to the online glossary at ***DrDavePoolInfo.com***.

*Dr. Dave is a PBIA Master Instructor, Dean of the Billiard University, and author of the book: The Illustrated Principles of Pool and Billiards and numerous instructional DVD series, all available at:* ***DrDaveBilliards.com****.*